out siege', met wives, and children, and kinsfolk after such a long absence in lands that were yet to feel like home.

While the siege of Mankot carried on, another marriage was arranged for the young Padshah who, as we have seen, was already married to Ruqaiya Begum. The bride-to-be was a granddaughter of Munim Khan and a daughter of Mirza Abdullah Moghul. It is clear that Bairam Khan was opposed to this marriage and, annoyed but unable to directly contradict Hamida Banu, he found excuses to keep delaying the inevitable 'until Nasir ul-mulk* informed him that to delay such affairs was extremely displeasing'. According to historian Iqtidar Alam Khan, this marriage had been decided by Hamida Banu and the ladies of the imperial harem in agreement with Munim Khan to block the dismayingly powerful influence of Bairam Khan upon Akbar, an influence clearly judged troubling. Bairam Khan found that he was increasingly thwarted in his designs in the next few months and tempers frayed, repeatedly.

Once the siege of Mankot was lifted, Sikandar Shah having finally surrendered in May 1557, the imperial party made its way towards Lahore. Rehabilitated, and then again dismissed, Sikandar Shah would die two years later, in Bengal. En route, Akbar enjoyed many elephant fights, this having become a veritable obsession. During one such fight, as the two elephants raged and crashed into each other, there was a loud commotion and amidst all the uproar Bairam Khan became convinced that Akbar was trying to have him trampled to death inside his tent. He sent a furious letter to Maham Anaga demanding 'of what sort of crime have trouble-makers accused me to cause such disfavour that he [Akbar] has set mad elephants upon me?' While Maham Anaga rushed to soothe Bairam Khan, Akbar, perhaps overwhelmed and conflicted by the atmosphere of suspicion and retribution at the camp, had grown 'sick of the sight of shortsighted people and flown into a rage'. Expressly forbidding anyone from following him, Akbar galloped away on a notoriously fiery Persian horse named Hayran, while his retinue waited in abashed silence. After he had returned to camp, he gathered only his immediate entourage and the small party went ahead to Lahore without informing Bairam Khan.

That Akbar should have felt frustrated and overcome at this point is understandable. After the death of his father, he had placed his trust in his ataliq to secure his throne and to fight his battles. He had been content to indulge in hunting and in elephant fights encouraged, possibly, by a